Eagle

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Boys Only

FX-01

Finding Xavier

Boys Only

The morning sun falls through the window and onto the display cabinet.

The badges stand in line, upright, like little toy soldiers.

Just like the Scout motto says, "Be prepared!"

Scout Leader: ... In a word—

Scout Leader: It's against the rules.

The child standing before the Scout leader doesn't respond. She's enraptured by the badges—the representation of a Scout's honor.

Every child who enters this room is attracted to them, but none more so than Eagle.

Her eyes are glued, sparkling with eagerness.

Eagle: ...

Scout Leader: Are you listening?

Eagle: S-sorry, sir, I ...

Eagle: I didn't catch that.

Scout Leader: I said that girls aren't allowed to join the Scouts. It's against the rules.

Scout Leader: Go home, kid.

Eagle: Please, just let me show my skills. Maybe then you'll change your mind. I've been working so hard and—

Scout Leader: No need to step forward.

Eagle: Yes, sir.

Scout Leader: Listen, kid, no girl has ever joined the Scouts, and no girl will ever join the Scouts.

Scout Leader: Let me see ... You applied 10 days ago, and a month ago, too. Didn't they tell you back then that girls weren't allowed?

Eagle: Yes, sir, they did ...

Scout Leader: Well, then it seems you're the problem. You don't remember what people tell you.

Scout Leader: You've got a short attention span—maybe even some kind of attention deficit. I'm afraid that doesn't meet the Scout's standards.

Eagle didn't expect such a simple mistake to lead to such irreparable consequences.

Eagle: But sir, you haven't seen my survival skills presentation—

She won't let this chance slip away from her like this. Not again.

Scout Leader: I don't need to.

Scout Leader: Look behind you. There's a whole line of people waiting to speak to me. A Scout must always "help others," remember?

She doesn't need to turn back to know that there's an orderly line of boys behind her, each with their eyes fixed on her.

She lowers her eyes and obediently recites the section of the Scout Oath.

Eagle: "... help other people at all times ..."

Scout Leader: Exactly. If you really want to be a Scout, you should start acting like one.

Eagle: But sir—

Scout Leader: You're also forgetting another law: "A Scout obeys orders." Something you're failing to do right now.

Eagle: ...

Eagle: Understood ...

Eagle: Sorry, sir.

Eagle: It's okay, it's okay ...

She whispers to herself, playing as her own comforter.

Eagle: What would Father do if he was rejected?

???: ... Mission ... Find the missing ...

???: ... Chemical plant ...

Fragments of a conversation drift through the partially opened door ahead.

Eagle halts, subconsciously holding her breath to better hear it.

As she carefully draws nearer to the source, the voice becomes clearer.

Scout Leader: His name is Xavier.

Scout Leader: I repeat, Xavier was last seen near the chemical plant. Your next mission is to find Xavier and take him back.

Scout Manual, Essential Virtues, Article III: "Be acute and seize opportunities."

Eagle: ...!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Young Detective

FX-02

Young Detective

The worn-down factory welcomes a pair of neatly dressed visitors.

Ignoring the workers and their looks, they walk over to an open space by a machine.

Investigator: Here we are.

Investigator: Please watch your step.

???: A factory filled with a load of run-down machinery. So, what's our mission?

Investigator: To improve the environment here. You need to cleanse this chemical plant with the arcane purification equipment provided.

Investigator: When you're done, you should perform a feasibility test to make sure all the machines are functioning properly.

???: Me? Do the whole thing?

Investigator: We believe you're competent enough to do so.

Investigator: While you prepare, we'll evacuate the workers and put up a Maze Net to ensure no one is injured or disturbs you.

Investigator: We'll make sure you have a safe and undisturbed working environment, as you stipulated.

???: Haha. I'm flattered.

???: By the way, do you smell something funny, like burning fat?

Investigator: No. This place shouldn't have any fat.

Investigator: But when we scouted out the site, we did deploy a number of Stinky Walking Cleaning Balls.

???: Ah, that must be it. Well, now it smells like stinky socks. Yikes.

???: Anyway ... Remind me again what we're doing here?

Investigator: Cleansing this chemical plant and performing a feasibility test.

Investigator: These measures are part of an agreement made between the Foundation and a number of severely polluted chemical plants.

Investigator: More Laplace staff members will come to assist you later.

???: ...

???: Please ask them to hurry.

???: Also, ask them to bring the latest gas masks, will you?

Scout Manual, Safety, Article VI: "Always assess the surroundings before taking action."

With her excellent tracking and concealment skills, Eagle follows the Scout team to the destination of their mission—

A chemical plant in the suburbs.

Amid the employees evacuating the factory, she watches the two members at the back of the Scout team from a distance.

Eagle: They're ... staying behind.

Eagle: I can't hear them from here ... Should I get closer?

She carefully closes the distance, keeping to the shadows to hide herself.

Eagle: Alright, now I can hear them.

Boy Scout I: This place gives me the creeps. Xavier must be really brave to come here!

Boy Scout I: Mike was right. His secret mission must be a tough one!

Boy Scout II: What? You really think he hasn't been home for two days because of some secret mission?

Boy Scout II: Mike isn't a detective, you know. He's just making stuff up!

Eagle: "Secret mission" ...

Boy Scout II: I still think this is—um, what's the word? A "kidnapping."

Boy Scout I: Humph, you're so wrong.

Boy Scout I: Adults always think that if a good boy runs away from home, he must've been kidnapped.

Boy Scout I: But I don't think so! I think Xavier came here for a secret mission!

Boy Scout I: To break up a huuuuge evil plan being hatched in an abandoned factory, like in the comic books, you know?

Boy Scout II: You can't be serious.

Boy Scout II: If anything breaks, it'll be our noses. This place stinks!

Boy Scout II: Achoo!

Eagle: Something's wrong with the environment here.

Boy Scout I: Sure does, but whoever finds Xavier will be promoted to team leader! I'll keep searching, even if my nose falls off!

Eagle: ...!

Boy Scout I: Today's the day I become a team leader! I can feel it!

Boy Scout II: Then why don't you go to the front of the team? That dummy George might find him first if you don't.

Boy Scout II: He did win the same number of badges as you for the charity sale.

Boy Scout I: Hey, I'm staying here to protect you! And just you wait, I'll figure out a way to beat him!

Boy Scout II: Whatever you say ... I think we've circled back on ourselves now.

Boy Scout I: I think you're right. Let's catch up with the others.

The boys walk away, still deep in conversation.

Eagle emerges from her hiding place, holding the pocket watch hung around her neck. The light of her arcane skill extends from the watch.

It points in the opposite direction to the boys'.

Eagle: They've left. I better hurry too.

Eagle stops herself. Don't rush into things—that's what she learned from the manual.

She takes a deep breath, straightens her bow, and starts forming a mission brief, like a real Scout would do.

Eagle: Name: Xavier, Sex: male, Age: between 7 and 18 years. Lives with his parents. Last seen around the chemical plant.

Eagle: May be on a secret mission.

Eagle: Whoever finds the missing person will be promoted to team leader of the Scouts team.

Eagle: ...

Eagle: Whoever finds Xavier will be promoted ... Then if I find him, will I have a chance, too?

Eagle: A chance to join the Scouts?

She grasps the pocket watch tighter, as if to gain courage from it.

The light of her arcane skill shines as firmly as the caster's gaze.

Eagle: I need to find Xavier before they do.

TO BE CONTINUED...

An Investigator's Guidebook

FX-03

An Investigator's Guidebook

Eagle: There are arcane skill fluctuations all around here.

It's unusual for there to be so many fluctuations out here in the suburbs.

The idea of a "secret mission" grows ever more convincing in her mind.

Eagle: "Secret mission" ... Maybe that's why there are so many fluctuations.

Eagle: And that's why they keep walking in circles. There's some arcane skill—or maybe an arcane item—that's messing with them.

She murmurs to herself, her head tilted in thought.

Eagle: I can't be sure for now ...

She decides to cast her arcane skill one more time.

She closes her eyes and concentrates hard. She senses a tiny spark of life.

She opens her eyes to find a small, fluffy surprise before her.

Eagle: Huh?

Puppy: Woof! Woof!

Eagle: A puppy? What are you doing here?

Puppy: Woof, woof woof!

The puppy nuzzles her ankle and looks up at her, as if begging for food.

Eagle rummages in her pockets and pulls out a half-eaten granola bar.

Eagle: You're hungry, aren't you? Do you want some of my granola bar? I can give you some.

Puppy: Woof woof!

Eagle: The ground's dirty. Just eat it from my hand. I'll break it up for you.

Eagle: Here you are—Oh!

The puppy devours the bar, turns tail, and leaves.

Puppy: Woof woof!

Eagle: Wait, that's a dead end!

Eagle: Huh?

Eagle: At least, it WAS a dead end ... Is there a gap here that the arcane skill doesn't cover?

Eagle: Or maybe I just didn't spot it before.

Eagle: It's probably just a blind spot. Dog holes are often hard to notice ...

Eagle: Oh, this corner's on my right, so I can use the right-hand rule ...

Eagle: I'm glad I spent the time to learn that one now.

Puppy: *whine*

The puppy scampers away.

Eagle: Hmm?

She hesitates. What matters more? A puppy, or a mission that isn't hers?

Eagle: Alright. Focus on the mission and find Xavier.

As her father once taught her, "An arcane skill can never perfectly disguise something. There will always be a flaw."

"Observe carefully, and you will find it." She scans the mud, the puddles, and the puppy's footprints.

Eagle: Footprints!

She cheerfully squats down, searching for other useful clues.

Eagle: No other tracks around ...

Eagle: ...

Eagle: Father said there are arcane skills that can remove all kinds of evidence. Maybe Xavier has this skill ...

Eagle: "If you're ever in a situation like that, use your arcane skill. But remember, don't push yourself too hard."

Eagle: I'll try again.

For the third time, she casts her arcane skill.

Scout Manual, Essential Virtues, Article V: "Be humble and prudent. Make rational assumptions."

???: Progress report: 10%.

No need to mention those trivial accidents.

???: Oh no. Don't fall, don't fall, don't—WHOA!

???: Well, there goes attempt number 14. Building the purification equipment has yet again ended in failure. There's not enough space, and the wires buckled under the weight.

???: Let me check the pollution rate before I try again ...

???: Uh-oh. Even if I started the purification process when I was born, I wouldn't see much improvement in the pollution levels using this equipment.

???: Then, why would someone use it? It's simple, yes, but completely useless—like the total opposite of a Goldberg machine!

???: Or maybe they just gave me the wrong equipment.

???: Regardless, it doesn't help me with my problem.

???: And I'm here to solve problems, not create new ones.

???: Right, let's take a closer look at this "latest advancement in Laplace equipment."

???: Oh, you have a nice bearing. I'll just "borrow" that ...

???: Now we're talking.

???: There's still time to save this place.

Eagle: ...?

Eagle: Oh ...!

Her breath quickens.

Eagle: I think I've found something!

The markings of an arcane skill. She follows them into the factory.

She gradually narrows the search as the traces converge to a single location, as if magnetized to it.

This spot doesn't seem to be concealed at all.

Eagle: The fluctuation of an arcane skill. North, behind the 11th pillar from the center.

Eagle: I found it!

???: I hate to say this, but if you don't make it here by sunset, the gas mask will be useless to me.

Operator: My apologies. The Laplace staff member is on the way. We appreciate your patience.

???: ...

He sighs. For a moment, he wants to hang up, but he stops himself.

???: Progress report: I am now suffering from anosmia and will suffocate in one hour.

???: If I'm lucky, I'll feel little pain before I lose consciousness.

???: Seriously, have you thought to confirm whether the staff have been kept out by your own Maze Net?

???: Hello? Huh. They've already hung up.

???: Well, I'll take that as my "get-out-of-jail-free card" to do whatever I want here!

???: Since no one's here yet, does this mean they've invented a truly impenetrable protective tool?

???: If it can't be broken by their own people, then surely it can't be broken by anyone. Absolute safety—what an invention!

???: ...

???: Anyway, maybe it's better they don't come. I can already see them denying my genius suggestions.

???: "Suggestion rejected. Please follow the rules."

???: And I'll say, "Rejection rejected! Please improvise!"

???: Then again, if I AM going to improvise, an assistant would be helpful.

???: Alright, almost there. But I still feel like there's something missing ...

???: Hmm ... What could it be?

Eagle: *panting*

Eagle: Excuse me ...

???: Maybe ... Hm? Who's that?

Eagle: Sorry to interrupt. Are you Xavier?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Giving A Hand

FX-04

Giving A Hand

X: ...

Eagle: ...

The two youngsters stare at each other in stunned silence.

They see confusion in each other's eyes.

Eagle: Um ...

X: A kid? Here?

X: Wait, how did you get in?

Eagle recalls another article in the Scout Manual.

Scout Manual, Safety, Article IX: "Avoid giving out personal information to strangers."

Eagle: You hardly look like an adult yourself ...

To her surprise, "Xavier" smiles.

X: I see what's going on here.

Eagle: You do?

X: Of course. You're here for me, right? Otherwise, you would've screamed, "A moving banana!" or something.

Eagle: Banana? What are you talking about?

X: Banana, orange, something like that. The Maze Net warps any trespasser's cognition, making them think of themselves and others as fruits. It stops them from moving any closer, since fruits don't have limbs.

X: Anyway, congratulations on passing through the Maze Net with your sanity still intact!

X: At least I think it's still intact ... So you're the staff member they sent?

X: Better late than never. Come, I could use your help.

Eagle: Okay, then ...

She looks up at the gigantic equipment in amazement.

Her curiosity quickly eclipses the question she intended to ask.

Eagle: Wow, what is this ... thing? Is this your "secret mission"?

X: Mission, yes. Secret? Maybe. It's ... off-the-record, if you know what I mean.

X: As you can see, I'm performing this mission according to what this place really needs.

Eagle: It looks ...

X: Spectacular? Magnificent? Go ahead. You can say both. But there's something missing, and I'm still trying to figure out what it is.

X: By the way, why aren't you wearing a uniform?

A question asked with no ill intentions still stings her.

Eagle subconsciously tightens her grip on her pocket watch.

It's hard to tell the truth to a stranger.

But a Scout should always be honest—she doesn't have a choice.

Eagle: I-I'm not an ...

Eagle: ... An official member.

X: Oh, so you're an intern.

X: It's okay. Maybe they'll make you a full-fledged member after this.

X: Don the white uniform and become a loyal—

Eagle: A loyal what?

X: Never mind. Oh, I've figured out what's missing! Come give me a hand.

Eagle: Sorry ...

X: What's wrong? Aren't you here to help?

Eagle: Actually, I'm here to take you back, Mr. Xavier.

X: ... Makes sense, since you don't have any gas masks with you.

X: And just call me "X."

Eagle: I-I'm sorry. I didn't have that information.

X: Didn't you check the mission briefing before you came here?

Eagle: The others have it, but I ... got separated from them.

X: Do they have the gas masks?

Eagle: Gas masks? What's a gas mask?

Eagle: Sorry, I should've collected more information ...

X: ...?

Eagle: Sir, if you really need this "gas mask," I'll go find it for you.

X looks puzzled. How could she not know what a gas mask is?

Perhaps this assistant is from this era, before they became widely used.

X: Forget it. We've got more important things to do. I don't want to miss this opportunity.

X: You know, those old fogeys are never willing to embrace new ideas.

Eagle: You're right. There are more important things to do.

Eagle takes a deep breath. She doesn't want to miss this chance.

She raises her head and stares at X with a firm look.

Eagle: Sir, please come with me. As for the "gas mask," I'll—

Whoosh!

Suddenly, a critter fur brush pulled from one of the machines shoots through the air ...

And makes its way straight for Eagle.

It lands on her sleeve, gently sweeping off the dust that has gathered on it.

Eagle: What's going on ...?

X: Forget the rules and regulations. You passed through the Net, so I already know you're much more capable than the others. And if you help me finish this task, I'll give my recommendation. Deal?

What a surprising offer!

Eagle: Recommendation ...?

She decides to seize this opportunity.

Eagle: Please, give me your command!

X: First, help me get this thing up and running, then we'll talk about what to do next. Clock's ticking, understand? We don't have much time.

Eagle: Copy that!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Listen To Your Gut

FX-05

Listen To Your Gut

With the help of Eagle, a massive Rube Goldberg machine begins to take shape.

The intricate machinery expands into the depths of the plant, with a dizzying amount of complexity.

X: Hmm, you know, it's not exactly what I had planned originally, but it shouldn't adversely affect the results.

Eagle: Uh, speaking of, mister—I wanted to ask ...

Eagle: Why does a smoke purification device need so many ... um ... explosives?

X: You're impeccably perceptive for an intern.

He blinks at her, and turns back to appreciate his masterpiece.

X: Don't worry about it, we're just recycling the base components from the explosives.

Eagle: So, are we done? Maybe we can go back as soon as—

X: —just need to adjust the circuit here. Hmm? Sorry, what did you say?

Eagle: Are we going back?

X: Sure, sure. Where else could we go if not back?

X: And of course, I won't forget about your recommendation letter when I get back.

Eagle: ...! Yes, sir! Thank you, sir!

X: You're welcome, but before that ...

X: Would you mind providing me with that unit we extracted from the "Purification Master 2.0."

Eagle: Got it!

Eagle hands him the unit. X kneels down, comparing it to the blank space on the machine.

X: —that won't do. It's the size isn't compatible.

X: This would be the optimal use-case for Laplace's "All-in-One Tool Kit 5.0."

X: You didn't happen to bring one along, did you?

Eagle: Laplace?

X: Hmm, what?

Eagle: Oh, nothing!

Eagle: I was just thinking ... your parents are probably really worried about you. Maybe we should head back.

X: Ah—

As soon as she finishes her sentence, there is a sharp turn in the mood between them.

X stands, turning to her with the device still in his palm.

His mouth curves into a smile, but it doesn't seem so friendly anymore.

X: It'd be better for you to not concern yourself too much with that.

Eagle: Why?

X: Now, shouldn't you go check on your other compatriots?

X: They've been lost in that maze a bit too long.

Eagle: Hmm ...

Eagle paces back and forth near the entrance to the seam, there's no sign of the puppy.

Eagle: The seam is bigger ... I guess the Maze Net thing is fading.

Eagle: Good thing no one's noticed it yet.

Eagle: I need to hurry up before they come.

The boy scouts are still stuck in their merry-go-round, circling one another over and over.

She nearly laughs at the sight, but is soon overwhelmed by a wave of guilt and awkwardness.

Eagle: ...

Eagle: Maybe Xavier doesn't get along with his parents.

Eagle: Or maybe it's something else.

She rubs her pocket watch; its metal shell is lined with scratches over a smooth surface.

Eagle: But no matter what, I shouldn't have spoken up like that.

Eagle: I should apologize. That is what a good scout has got to do.

Eagle: Right.

Eagle looks back at the top of the plant, determined.

Eagle: I have to go back to Xavier.

X: Hey, welcome back!

X: Perfect timing. We're all set, all we need now is the right vantage from which to enjoy it.

X: This chimney should work.

Eagle: Mr. Xavier—

Half of his body is sunk into the chimney pipe.

X: Again, call me "X."

Eagle: Mr. X, be careful—

X: Shh. Save your words for the way back. Come on, the spectacle is about to begin.

Eagle: But—

X: Can you get up here on your own?

Eagle: Y-yes! Just need a second or two!

Completely unaware of what's to come, she climbs up the cement chimney and stands next to X.

Scout Manual, Essential Virtues, Article VIII: "Ask less, act more."

X: Hold on to something.

Eagle: Yes, sir!

X: Alright. Then—

X: Let's get this show on the road.

TO BE CONTINUED...

An Explosive Answer

FX-06

An Explosive Answer

The plant collapses in a catastrophic rumble, spewing up a cloud of dust.

There was nothing in the Scout Manual that accounted for a circumstance like this. Her mouth lies open and slack-jawed.

A synthetic earthquake—all to the "credit" of the maestro beside her.

X: *cough*

X: Even when you know what's coming, it still never ceases to amaze, am I right?

Eagle: Mr. X ...

X: Yeah?

Eagle: I thought ... I thought you said this was a smoke purification device.

X: I did say that. What better way of purifying smoke is there than getting rid of it altogether?

Eagle: But ... it's not—

X: I promise, kid, it's completely safe.

X: Before you got here, we evacuated the plant, so neither humans nor arcanists were harmed.

Eagle: And critters—

X: And none of them too!

X: No one will have even noticed. The Maze Net should prevent all the noise from leaking.

Eagle: But the Maze Net isn't working anymore! I came in through a seam in it!

X: Oh, alright. Well ... no big deal.

X: Just like it's no big deal that you're not really an intern from Laplace.

Eagle: What ...?!

Her heartbeat shoots up, her grip tightening on her pocket watch so hard that the clasp pokes into her skin.

X: Yeah, you're not from Laplace. Albeit, you've figured out some way in through the Maze Net. I'm impressed, Laplace technology isn't easily beat.

X: I'm curious, though. How did you locate me here? Did you use some arcane gadgets?

Eagle: No, just my arcane skill. Wait, who are you? Are you Xavier or not?

X: I'm "X."

The realization sets in, he never once accepted the name she labeled him with.

Eagle: Yes, right ... You did say that.

Eagle: So, then you're "X" ...

A gaggle of quarreling boy scouts interrupts her revelation.

Boy Scout I: Told you I'd figure it out!

Boy Scout I: That crash was huge! Must have freaked out Xavier. So, he'll probably run out from there!

Eagle: ...

X: Ah. The Maze Net has definitely failed then.

Eagle: I-I need to find the real Xavier. I—

Boy Scout I: Hey! Aren't you the girl that was bothering our scout leader? Hasn't he told you like a hundred times already? Girls CAN'T join the scouts!

Eagle: It wasn't a hundred times ...

Boy Scout I: Why don't you give up already? Whoever heard of a scout in a skirt!

X: I think the Scottish Scouts might hold a different opinion on that ...

Boy Scout I: Who are YOU? Don't tell me, because I don't care what they do there, here in Washington girls can't be scouts! Just look at that dumb old rag on her—not even close to a real sash!

Eagle: Step aside, please.

Boy Scout II: Wait a second, they were here when this place exploded!

Boy Scout I: It must be their fault! What if Xavier is buried down there! What if he's dead? Some scout you are!

Boy Scout I: Yeah, even if you did get let in, we'd never swap scarves with you!

Eagle: Xavier can't be ... Mr. X said no one was harmed!

Boy Scout I: Where's George? Are the rest of them still walking in circles?

Eagle: I'm leaving. Get out of the way, please.

Boy Scout I: Who says you can leave?

X: Sorry, why can't she leave?

Boy Scout II: Because if we can't find Xavier, then we've got to take her in. It's probably her fault this place blew up!

Eagle: I'm going to find Xavier.

Boy Scout I: Oh, yeah—How? You don't even know what he looks like!

The boys stand together blocking her way out.

She stops. The thought of barging right through them crosses her mind, but just looking at their uniforms makes her too bitter to start.

Eagle: If he's not here, then he's got to be somewhere else. No matter what, I—

X: You'll find him.

X: Now there's no place for him to hide. You'll find him sooner or later.

X: And you know what? Even if you don't, you can go back to Laplace with me.

X: I can tell you're a kid carrying a heavy burden, and kids like you always need to do something. Anything.

X: So, want to find something that you can do?

Eagle stares at him blankly, unsure of what he really means.

She decides to focus on her current mission.

Eagle: No, thank you, sir. I will find it on my own, with my arcane sk—

"Arcane skill." The moment she says it out loud, she'll have outed herself as an arcanist.

She won't need to hide anything anymore, but then the possibility of ever joining the scouts will shoot right down to zero.

Thankfully, a cheerful bark interrupts her words.

Puppy: Woof! Woof!

The missing puppy runs towards her, snuggling her feet like an old friend.

Eagle: Oh? It's you!

Boy Scout I: Xavier? Is that you?

The puppy barks back, as if confirming his identity.

"Xavier": Woof!

X: Oh.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Puppy Comes Home

FX-07

The Puppy Comes Home

The moment Xavier touches Eagle's feet, the dim lines around him disappear.

He seems to notice it as well, chasing his tail as if looking for its invisible trace.

Somehow puppies always manage to be the smartest in the room. Even when outdoors.

Eagle: It's you.

X: Seems like he likes you. I thought I heard something barking before ...

X: And you proved me right.

Boy Scout I: Hey! We found Xavier! That reward is ours!

Eagle: You didn't find him. He found us.

Boy Scout I: What did you say?

Boy Scout II: Let's see if he meets the description: brown, curly fur, tag on his collar ...

Eagle gently grasps the dog's collar and wipes the dust from his tag.

Eagle: Turns out you were here with me the whole time.

Boy Scout II: ... It's got an "X" on it, X for Xavier.

X: What a coincidence.

Boy Scout II: That's him alright.

Xavier answers with an upbeat woof.

Boy Scout II: So, how do we take him back?

Boy Scout I: Let me try, Xavi—

"Xavier": WOOF!

Boy Scout I: Hey! He snapped at me!

Eagle: The Scouts Manual clearly says never to reach for a distressed animal.

Eagle: He seems to trust me, I can take him back with you.

Boy Scout I: You're not even a scout! Who says you can go with us?

X: Because I don't think Xavier will go along with you little credit-stealing twerps.

X: Am I right?

The puppy looks up affectionately at X. He smiles back.

X: Also, weren't you just asking her to go back with you?

Boy Scout I: Um ...

Eagle: Mr. X.

Eagle: Are those people over there your partners? Their clothes are similar to yours.

X: What—OH, SHOOT.

Even before he can read their expressions, the look of the people approaching in white spells trouble for him.

X: That's ... an emergency. See you later!

Eagle: Hmm? Okay, Mr. X, see you.

Boy Scout II: What's going on with him?

Eagle: Dunno. Let's just go back.

Scout Leader: I understand.

Scout Leader: Now, take Xavier out to Mrs. Clark. She's waiting for him.

Boy Scout I: What about her? She and her weirdo friend blew up the—

Scout Leader: Scouts, you don't have to repeat it for me.

Boy Scout II: Let's go, Matt.

Boy Scout I: Whose side are you even on?

Boy Scout II: I just think maybe Xavier will want to see his owner soon ...

The boys take the dog and leave.

The little disturbance doesn't distract Eagle. She stares intently at the scout leader, hanging on every word he might say.

A simple distraction may lead to serious consequences. She has learned her lesson.

As the leader looks at her, she straightens her back even more.

Eagle: Sir, I want to join the scouts.

Scout Leader: Kid, it's not even been six hours since the last time I turned you down. I haven't changed my mind.

Scout Leader: Besides, all I've got is your word that says you're the one that found Xavier.

Eagle wrings her hands. Despite all the instructions in the Scout Manual to the contrary, she blurts out.

Eagle: If you don't trust me, why did you ask me to stay?

There is a mix of pain and confusion in the question.

Scout Leader: Because I know Matt well.

Scout Leader: He wouldn't make something like this up.

Eagle: So, you believe me?

Scout Leader: I believe them. And what they told me is that factory crumbled to pieces and the noise is what brought Xavier out.

Scout Leader: Now, Matt blamed you and your friend, but I can't see how two teenagers could take down a whole building, and anyway, he agreed you were the one that brought the dog back.

Scout Leader: So, against my better judgement, if your friend vouches for you, I'll give you the merit badge.

A tempting offer. Her eyes glint, but the light soon fades.

She doesn't even know where to find this so-called "friend."

Eagle: ...

Scout Leader: What, you don't think your friend will come?

She clenches the pocket watch, rubbing the cover.

Its familiar scratches giving her the courage to speak.

Eagle: I-I can vouch for myself, sir. I'll show you my a-arcane skill!

Scout Leader: Arcane skill?

Scout Leader: Of course, arcane skill. Like that's going to prove anything.

Eagle: Sir—

Scout Leader: Two choices, young lady. Either ask your friend to vouch for you and get the badge, or give up and don't come back.

Scout Leader: Either way, don't ever mention your arcane skill again.

Scout Leader: Don't waste my time.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Butterfly Flaps Its Wings

FX-08

A Butterfly Flaps Its Wings

Eagle: ...

Alone in the cemetery, Eagle stands in front of her father's tombstone.

She hadn't been alone long, only a few moments ago a stranger had been there, leaving her with a troubled mind.

It's already difficult enough to keep composed whenever she's here.

Eagle: Sorry to keep you waiting, dad.

Eagle: Did you hear what he just said? "It isn't too far from Lorentz here."

She crouches over and props up the flowers she brought. Petals from the last time are still caught in the creases of the stone.

Loss makes you age beyond your years—it can't be helped. But maturity has its benefits.

Eagle: He said he was your colleague. That you used to be friends.

Eagle: Like Matt and his friends?

Eagle: But I don't really understand ...

Eagle: He mentioned Lorentz, and Laplace ... What was that all about? Should I know anything about them?

Eagle: And if I do this, what does that mean? Am I following in your footsteps?

Eagle: I can memorize every word in The Scouts Manual, but ...

Eagle: But I'll never know if I made you proud.

She shakes her head, trying to rid herself of that thought.

Eagle: A few days ago, back in Brooklyn, I met someone else.

Eagle: He, um ... did I talk about it already?

Eagle: ...

Eagle: He asked me a question, but I didn't answer. I didn't know how to answer—

Eagle: He asked me, "Want to find something that you can do?"

Eagle: Just like what Mr. X said to me.

Eagle: I'm just confused, dad.

Eagle: But maybe one day I'll understand, right?

Her gaze turned from the worn old sash in her hands back to the tombstone.

Eagle: Right, I will.

She's passing through alleys and over fences, swift as a breath of wind.

It'd been a few days since she and her mom came to visit her aunts. The first thing to do after settling in was to get the lay of the land.

She's learned to do this well, anything to protect her mother and herself.

Eagle: Next corner turn right, and then half a block away ...

Eagle: I need to hurry up ...

Eagle: Or mom will get worried.

She leaps lightly into the room, without drawing any attention.

???: ... would be a better place.

Eagle: Hi mom, I'm back—Mom?

X: Oh, hi. Not your mom, but welcome back!

Eagle: ...!

Eagle: Mr. X! Why are you here?

X: I said see you later. Remember?

Eagle: You—

Mother: Oh, look at you, your shirt is all wet. Go change out of those clothes. Next time I'll go with you, so you don't get up to trouble.

Eagle: Sorry, mom, but there's something ... I need your advice.

Mother: Alright, but we're drying your hair first.

Eagle: I met a man in the cemetery, and he said he worked with dad.

Eagle: Do you think you might know him?

She looks over to X as she talks to her mom. X makes a gesture to the door.

Eagle shakes her head disapprovingly.

Mother: It's possible, sweetie—especially if he recognized you. But, I couldn't say without seeing him myself.

Mother: But please be careful talking to strangers ... especially with you're out there all alone.

Eagle: He told me, father wasn't just in the military, but also a member of "Lorentz."

Eagle: I don't know what that is, but if dad worked there, then maybe ... I can join them instead of the scouts?

Mother: Sweetheart, all I ever wanted is for you to be healthy and happy.

Mother: You can join the scouts or Lorentz, or anything! I will support you, no matter what.

X: Hmm? That sounds like one of my colleagues.

X: Take this question as the continuation of that conversation.

X: Would you like to join Laplace with me?

Eagle: I ... I don't know what Laplace and Lorentz are.

Eagle: But are girls allowed to join?

X: Oh, we don't care about any of that. You can join us even if you're neither a boy nor a girl.

X: But that's really beside the point. As far as you are concerned, Laplace and Lorentz are two different organizations, but we share an office. It's not far from here actually. I can give you a more detailed introduction if you like.

Eagle: But my dad is gone. I need to take care of my mom. Besides, we don't live here, so I can't stay long.

X: Hmm, but your mom just told me you're moving.

Eagle: Is that true?

Mother: Well, your aunties are here, and I want to be closer to your father.

Mother: Though I still can't bear to go there, but I will one day.

Eagle: ...

Eagle: But, why me? I didn't really help all that much.

X: Nah, you were a perfect assistant. Remember, you helped me with that equipment, or was that someone else?

X: Besides, you successfully found "X," both of us, which showed your acute observation skills and capability under pressure.

X: All in all, I think you'd be wasted on the scouts, you deserve to shine bright, not waste your time collecting tin badges.

Eagle: I-I do?

X: You heard me.

X: And I'm here to show you another way.

Eagle: This is ...

Eagle: A uniform, it's a little like yours!

Eagle: Is this an official uniform?

X: Yes, and this is the other way I'm offering you.

X: The way to the Institutum Lorentz.

Eagle: Lorentz. Another way ...

X: That's right.

X: Because after that mission ...

X: I think you shouldn't be looking for a puppy, but a butterfly.

THE END